



Cancer combat club

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

It's 40,000 sq ft of sparkling, clean floors, where researchers in search of miracles work with cutting-edge technologies. Their average age is 31 and they are on a mission: to find new vaccines and bio-therapeutic products to help combat cancer. This is also the band of young researchers that includes Research Director Ashok Khar and Principal Scientist Samir Kumar Roy who have made the first indigenous recombinant DNA-based hepatitis B vaccine. They work for India's first bio-pharma

A team of students proves that money isn't the force that drives the quest for cures

company, Shantha Biotechnics in Hyderabad that started in 1993.

Khar, a cancer immunologist, resigned from the Centre for Cellular Molecular Biology (CCMB) two years ago, to become research head. Just like 48-year-old Roy who returned five years ago to his homeland after 11 years overseas. And then there's D. Vijayarangam, who also quit CCMB to join the cause.

While Shantha Biotechnics isn't the best paymaster in the industry, it

does provide the right ambience for discovery. And money isn't always a criterion for these researchers. They want ideal working conditions, reliable instrumentation and access to a range of chemicals.

This is in keeping with the company's credo, says Managing Director K.I. Varaprasad Reddy. "Our faith is in totally indigenous technologies. Nothing bought, borrowed or stolen and that is why 25 per cent of our turnover goes back into research and development." Addressing critical health care measures, this young team of scientists is out to prove that even creation can be bettered.

Rs 200

CRORE WAS THE TOTAL REVENUE OF THE BIOTECH INDUSTRY IN 2006, WHICH WAS DOUBLE ITS TOTAL REVENUE IN 2004

CURE HUNTERS: Inside Shantha Biotechnics



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